Business Management

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Business Management

1. Purpose of the Investigation

Figure 1: Business Management —

This report asks one question.

> Do the major theories of business management correspond structurally to the five-stage model: Field ( ), Wave ( ), Boundary ( ), Vortex ( ), Bundle ( )?

Business management is one of the richest domains in the thirty-domain survey for testing structural correspondence with the five-stage model. It contains dense descriptions of organization, knowledge, innovation, entrepreneurship, and institutional change.

At the same time, it is also one of the riskiest domains. Management theories often use highly general vocabulary, which makes superficial resemblance easy to mistake for structural correspondence. For that reason, this domain required the strictest control against overreading.

This document is a report of findings. It is neither a management guide nor a recommendation of particular theories. It separates places where the correspondence is dense from places where interpretive restraint is necessary.

2. Method of Investigation

Scope

Eleven theories and practical models were selected for evaluation in this domain. They include organizational knowledge creation, design thinking, small-group development, disruptive innovation, the learning organization, exploration and exploitation, sensemaking, TPS/Lean, effectuation, antifragility, and Theory U.

The selection rested on three criteria.

1. The theory must explicitly describe processes of generation, transformation, learning, or institutionalization.
2. Structural comparison must be possible on the basis of primary texts or well-established secondary literature.
3. The set of theories must allow comparison across different lineages within business management.

Evaluation Method

For each theory, the investigation first clarifies what the theory is trying to describe. It then examines where correspondence with the five stages can be found. Judgments were made by considering the theory's core concepts, typical examples, transitions between stages, whether circulation from Bundle to the next Field is visible, and how high the risk of forced analogy is.

The mappings presented here are interpretive hypotheses, not one-to-one transfers of the original texts. The five-stage labels are themselves convenient cuts made within a continuum, and the labels used by each theory are equally gradient-like. The correspondences therefore need to be read as structured interpretations rather than as exact equivalences.

This comparison also includes AI-assisted stages of reading and drafting. Some parts have not yet been fully rechecked through the author's own close reading. For that reason, the overall temperature of the report is best understood as a strong provisional conclusion.

How to Read the Judgments

- Strong correspondence: the theory aligns naturally with multiple stages, and the reason can be explained in the main text.
- Correspondence requiring restraint: a correspondence is visible, but differences in scope or descriptive level matter.
- Open question: the present material does not justify fixing a single interpretation yet.

Limits of the Investigation

This is not an exhaustive historiographical study of every work associated with each theory. It extracts the core concepts of major works at a granularity suitable for comparison. Some internal disputes, terminological nuances, and historical details are therefore left aside.

3. Overview of the Five-Stage Model

The five-stage model describes the movement of creation through the following phases.

Stage	Definition
Field	An undifferentiated state in which neither direction nor form has yet been fixed. It is the matrix of possibility.
Wave	A stage in which differences and oscillations emerge and multiple directions begin to compete.
Boundary	A stage in which differences are not immediately resolved but are rewoven as relations.

Stage	Definition
Vortex	A stage in which a new coherence or form rises out of those relations.
Bundle	A stage in which the form settles and remains as a reusable structure.

The model is not linear. Bundle becomes the condition for the next Field, and circulation follows. Nor are the stages separate boxes. They overlap and transition into one another as parts of a continuum.

If some discomfort remains at this point, that discomfort is itself an important perspective for the investigation. Readers may continue while keeping it in view.

4. Overall Picture of the Findings

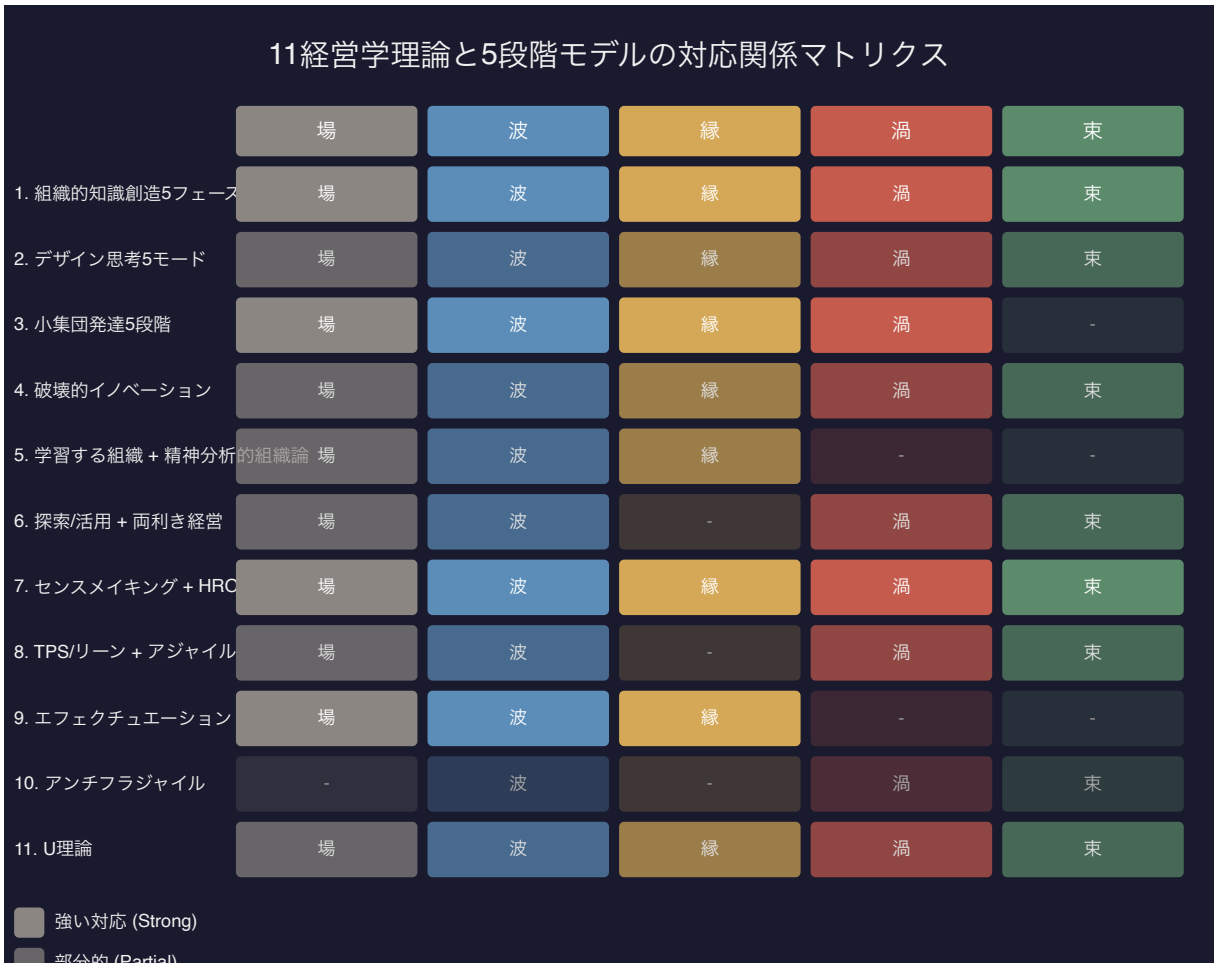

Figure 2: Business Management — ×5

Theories Evaluated

Theory	Main Proponents	Most Visible Phases	Main Finding
Organizational Knowledge Creation 5 Phases + SECI/Ba	Nonaka & Takeuchi et al.	Field to Bundle	Bundle as institutional carry-over is especially clear.
d.school Design Thinking	d.school, Brown	Field to Bundle	The correspondence is dense, but the formalized reception of the model must be separated from its core.
Tuckman's 5 Stages of Group Development	Tuckman	Field to Bundle	One of the cleanest stage anchors in the domain.
Disruptive Innovation	Christensen	Wave to Bundle	It clearly shows how existing structures reject weak signals.
The Learning Organization	Senge et al.	Wave to Bundle	Learning and dialogue are described with unusual thickness.
Exploration/Exploitation + Ambidexterity	March et al.	Field and Bundle	Especially useful for understanding fixation in Bundle and return to Field.
Sensemaking + HRO	Weick et al.	Wave to Boundary to Bundle	One of the strongest descriptions of Boundary in the whole domain.
TPS/Lean + Agile	Ohno et al.	Wave to Bundle	Institutionalization and iterative improvement are especially strong.
Effectuation	Sarasvathy	Field to Boundary	It gives one of the clearest entrepreneurial descriptions of Boundary.
Antifragile + Black Swan	Taleb	Wave to Bundle	Best read as a theory of response characteristics rather than of process.
Theory U	Scharmer et al.	Descent into Field, then Bundle	Its distinctive contribution is to make the path into Field visible.

All eleven theories showed some degree of structural correspondence in the present re-reading. The certainty is not uniform, however. Tuckman, Weick, and effectuation work well as anchor theories. Design thinking, antifragility, and Theory U are intellectually attractive but require the greatest restraint against overinterpretation.

What is thickest in this domain is the movement from Boundary to Vortex and the institutionalization of Bundle. Business management repeatedly asks how relations are organized, how a new form emerges from that organization, and how the resulting form remains as procedure, culture, or system.

5. Examination of the Major Theories

5.1 Nonaka and Takeuchi: Organizational Knowledge Creation 5 Phases + SECI/Ba

Nonaka and Takeuchi describe organizational knowledge creation as a sequence of sharing tacit knowledge, conceptualization, justification, prototyping, and cross-leveling. The SECI model provides a different axis for describing transformations between tacit and explicit knowledge.

The correspondence to the five-stage model is comparatively clear. Sharing tacit knowledge aligns with Field, conceptualization with Wave, justification with Boundary, prototyping with Vortex, and cross-leveling with Bundle. Cross-leveling is especially important because it shows how a result remains beyond the local scene and becomes a condition for subsequent cycles.

Ba, however, should not be treated as identical to Field. Ba refers to a social context in which knowledge creation takes place. It therefore lies one level outside the five-stage Field. Once that distinction is kept in view, this theory becomes one of the strongest descriptions of circulation and institutional carry-over in the domain.

5.2 d.school Design Thinking

The d.school model presents Empathize, Define, Ideate, Prototype, and Test as nonlinear and iterative modes. Brown's account likewise centers on repeated movement between observation, framing, prototyping, and feedback.

The mapping becomes legible when Empathize is read as Field, Ideate as Wave, Define as Boundary, Prototype as Vortex, and Test together with iterative learning as Bundle. Yet the model has been widely proceduralized in practice, and that raises a serious question: are we reading the core theory, or a formalized managerial reception of it?

Three possibilities remain open. First, the current comparison may be reading a flattened version of design thinking. Second, what appears here may be not mere similarity but another language for the deeper motor of creative movement. Third, the five-stage model and design thinking may partially overlap as neighboring descriptions of the same phenomenon. For that reason, this is both a strong candidate and one of the theories that most demands restraint.

5.3 Tuckman's Five Stages of Small Group Development

Tuckman's model describes group development through Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing, and Adjourning. Its central concern is how a group moves from initial gathering through conflict and coordination to productive cooperation and dissolution.

The correspondence is unusually direct. Forming aligns with Field, Storming with Wave, Norming with Boundary, and Performing with Vortex. The difficult case is Adjourning, but when it is read not as mere disappearance but as the moment in which outcomes, shared learning, and role inheritance remain for future teams and procedures, it can be read naturally as Bundle.

The importance of this theory lies in the fact that conflict is not treated as failure. Wave is a necessary passage. If it is bypassed, the quality of Boundary and Vortex declines. That is why Tuckman remains one of the most useful anchor theories in this domain.

5.4 Christensen: Disruptive Innovation

Christensen describes how technologies that initially look weak enter from low-end or new markets and eventually reorganize the market itself. The theory is centered on the paradox that firms fail precisely while acting "rationally" within existing structures.

An existing value network corresponds to Field. A weak signal in the form of a disruptive technology corresponds to Wave. Experimentation at the low end or in a new market corresponds to Boundary. The growth of the new market corresponds to Vortex. The settled post-transition market structure corresponds to Bundle.

The value of this theory is that creation is shown not only as the appearance of something new, but as a selective structure that decides which signals will be ignored and which will be taken seriously. In that sense, it also describes fixation in Bundle with unusual clarity.

5.5 Senge: The Learning Organization + Bion's Psychoanalytic Group Theory

Senge's learning organization places systems thinking, personal mastery, mental models, shared vision, and team learning at the center of organizational learning. When Bion's group dynamics are brought in, the theory also becomes useful for explaining why learning stalls.

Systems thinking aligns with Field, creative tension with Wave, dialogue with Boundary, and shared vision with the movement from Vortex into Bundle. Dialogue is especially important because it describes a situation in which difference is not removed too early but held long enough to reorganize relation.

The psychoanalytic layer is best used as a supporting line rather than as the main argument. The center of gravity remains the learning organization itself. Bion helps explain why groups fail to move beyond Wave, but should not be allowed to displace the primary theory.

5.6 March: Exploration/Exploitation + Ambidexterity

March defines exploration as the pursuit of the new and exploitation as the refinement of the known. Ambidexterity asks how an organization can sustain both without collapsing into one side.

Exploration corresponds most clearly to the movement from Field through Boundary, whereas exploitation corresponds to the movement from Vortex into Bundle. The garbage can model is also significant here because it gives a social description of Field as a condition in which problems, solutions, participants, and opportunities drift before becoming temporarily organized.

The strength of this theory lies in its account of creative failure as fixation in Bundle. Once an organization becomes too attached to a successful form, the pathway back to Field narrows. By contrast, Boundary itself is not described with equal density, so this theory works best as a theory of oscillation between openness and fixation.

5.7 Weick: Sensemaking + HRO

Weick's theory of sensemaking describes the social process by which experience becomes meaningful. Extracted cues, plausibility, retrospectivity, and enactment are all central. HRO extends this into the domain of high-reliability operations.

This is one of the strongest accounts of the transition from Wave to Boundary. Ambiguous cues drift in Field. Awareness of difference becomes Wave. Enactment rewrites the relation between action and environment, which makes it an especially strong description of Boundary. Plausible stories cluster as Vortex, and institutionalized meaning remains as Bundle.

Boundary is the decisive strength here. The environment is not simply given. It is shaped through action and in turn constrains action. That bidirectional structure makes this theory one of the main calibration points for Boundary in the whole domain.

5.8 TPS/Lean + Agile

TPS describes a system built around going to the actual place, detecting abnormalities, stopping the line, standardizing work, and improving continuously. Lean and Agile can be read as later developments of this logic across other industries.

Genchi genbutsu aligns with Field. Abnormality detection and the Five Whys align with Wave. Reviews and stakeholder contact align, more implicitly, with Boundary. MVPs and prototypes align with Vortex. Standardized work and kaizen align with Bundle.

The strongest phases here are Wave, Vortex, and Bundle. Boundary is present, but less explicitly. TPS is more interested in turning fluctuation into disciplined form than in dwelling on relation as such. That is why it is especially powerful for understanding institutionalization.

5.9 Sarasvathy: Effectuation

Effectuation describes how expert entrepreneurs decide under uncertainty. Its five principles are Bird-in-Hand, Affordable Loss, Crazy Quilt, Lemonade, and Pilot-in-the-Plane.

Bird-in-Hand aligns with Field, Lemonade with Wave, Crazy Quilt with Boundary, the clustering of a new purpose with Vortex, and the institutionalization of a business with Bundle. Crazy Quilt is especially important because stakeholders are not fully selected in advance. Purpose arises through commitment within relation itself.

This theory matters because it does not treat creation as the execution of a pre-given goal. Instead, goals shift through the interaction of available means and emerging commitments. For that reason, effectuation stands with Weick as one of the strongest theories of Boundary in business management.

5.10 Taleb: Antifragile + Black Swan

Taleb proposes the threefold distinction between the fragile, the robust, and the antifragile. Black Swan events, Skin in the Game, Optionality, and the barbell strategy are part of the same conceptual field.

The key point is that this is not best read as a five-stage process of generation. It is better read as a theory of design principles and response characteristics under uncertainty. On that reading, a stable state aligns with Field, the arrival of the stressor with Wave, bodily exposure to the stressor with Boundary, overcompensation with Vortex, and time-tested stabilization with Bundle.

This makes Taleb highly valuable, but in a specific way. It clarifies what kinds of structures become stronger under uncertainty. It does not directly narrate the step-by-step emergence of new form. The difference between process and system characteristic therefore has to remain explicit.

5.11 Scharmer: Theory U

Theory U describes transformation through seven stages: Downloading, Seeing, Sensing, Presencing, Crystallizing, Prototyping, and Performing. Its central image is the descent and ascent of a U-shaped process.

The grounds for compressing seven stages into five can be stated clearly. Seeing and Sensing both belong to Wave because both suspend existing frameworks and deepen sensitivity to difference. Presencing is the deepest arrival into Field. Crystallizing is the unique moment in which collective intention begins to take form after that descent, so it is best read as Boundary. Prototyping aligns with Vortex, and Performing aligns with Bundle.

The distinctive contribution of Theory U is that it gives a thick description of the path into Field. The five-stage model begins from Field, whereas Theory U asks how existing patterns are relinquished so that Field becomes reachable. At the same time, its empirical grounding is weaker than that of the strongest theories in this domain, so interpretive caution remains necessary.

6. Cross-Cutting Findings

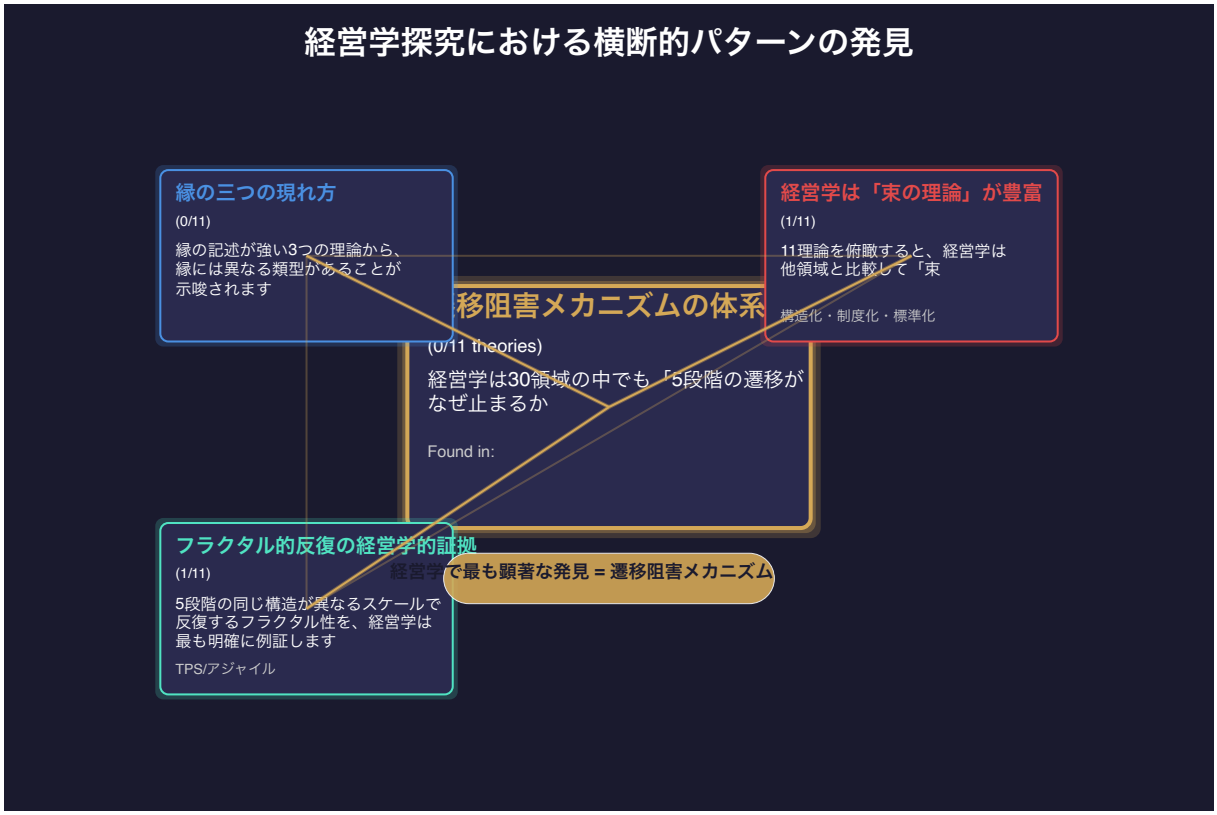

Figure 3: Business Management —

First, Boundary is richly described in this domain. Tuckman gives it the form of norm formation. Weick gives it the form of enactment. Effectuation gives it the form of Crazy Quilt. Design thinking gives it the form of reframing before prototyping. Business management repeatedly returns to the reorganization of relation.

Second, Bundle is not treated as a mere ending point. In Nonaka and Takeuchi it appears as cross-leveling. In Tuckman it appears as what remains after adjournment. In TPS it appears as standardized work and institutionalized improvement. In Christensen it appears as a reorganized market structure. The domain is therefore unusually strong at describing how a result remains.

Third, the more appealing a theory is, the more carefully its descriptive level has to be checked. Antifragility is a theory of response characteristics. Theory U is especially strong on the movement prior to entering Field. Design thinking requires a distinction between its theoretical core and its widely circulated procedural format.

Fourth, business management repeatedly preserves a path back to Field. Organizational carry-over, improvement cycles, inheritance after dissolution, and renewed attention to weak signals all show Bundle producing the conditions for another beginning. This suggests that the domain is concerned not only with creation as an event, but with the conditions for its continuation.

7. Unresolved Questions

1. In design thinking, does the apparent correspondence arise from the theoretical core or from the later practical format through which the theory was popularized?
2. How far can a theory of response characteristics such as antifragility be integrated into comparison with theories of generation?
3. Can the path into Field described by Theory U be found with equal clarity in other theories?
4. Is the return from Bundle to the next Field a general feature of this domain, or only a strong feature of a few theories?
5. Are the structures described here immanent to the theories themselves, or are they analytical structures extracted for the purpose of comparison?

8. Conclusion

Business management turned out to be one of the densest domains in the full survey for testing correspondence with the five-stage model. Its strongest contributions lie in the description of Boundary and in the institutionalization of Bundle. Weick, Tuckman, effectuation, Nonaka and Takeuchi, and TPS function as the core evidence of the domain.

That result does not mean that the same five stages appear fully and without remainder in every theory. Some theories offer dense correspondence, while others require more restraint because of differences in scope or descriptive level. What matters is not the raw count of correspondences, but which moment is described thickly and in what vocabulary.

At present, the strongest conclusion is that business management offers an unusually rich vocabulary for relation-building, experimentation, institutionalization, and renewed circulation. This is a powerful reading, but it remains interpretive rather than final. Further validation through the author's own close reading is especially needed for design thinking, antifragility, and Theory U.